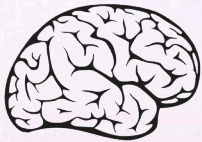


IDENTIFIED 7 OF THE 12 CRANIAL NERVES, INCLUDING THE OPTIC AND ACOUSTIC NERVES



MADE THERIAC REMEDY OUT OF 60 INGREDIENTS TO TREAT EMPEROR MARCUS AURELIUS

WROTE AROUND 500 WORKS, OF WHICH 20,000 PAGES SURVIVE

the attention of the emperor, Marcus Aurelius. In 169 CE, Aurelius asked Galen to be his personal physician, describing him as “first among doctors and unique among philosophers.” Galen was later the physician of the next two emperors: Lucius Commodus and Septimius Severus.

Medical theory and practice

In his book *On Anatomical Procedures*, Galen spoke of the importance of dissection and observation. Although his experience of dissection was limited to animals, he made some very important discoveries, including findings relating to the functions of many organs. The great cerebral vein (in the skull), which he identified, is still known as “the vein of Galen.”

Galen believed that the body had three connecting systems: the brain and nerves; the heart and arteries, which he said were responsible for “vital energy”; and the liver and veins, where he said blood was formed and distributed around the body. He dispelled some misconceptions, revealing that the kidneys, not the bladder, make urine; that the heart has valves; and that arteries carry blood, not air, as was previously thought. He worked out that the spinal cord transmits messages to the brain and identified which nerves are involved in movement and speech.

Treating many illnesses such as malaria (which he called “fever”) and smallpox (known as “plague”), Galen set great store by listening to patients and observing them, including taking a detailed record of their pulse—a procedure he described in his book *De Pulsibus*. He believed that diet, exercise, and good hygiene were important, and thought there was a strong connection between the

mind and the body, saying that anger could exacerbate fever and anxiety could result in insomnia.

The ancient Greeks believed that health was influenced by the four “humors”: bodily fluids that caused a person to be sanguine, choleric, phlegmatic, or melancholic. While Galen accepted this idea, he also expanded on it. Unlike

